resistance to Mughal power, its ‘settled repugnance…to sully the purity of its blood’, and castigating all the other clans who had ‘degraded’ themselves. Forgotten was the fact that Rajput clans had long fought each other, and that women had committed sati and jauhar in the face of opposing Rajputs, as had happened when the Bhati Rajputs had committed saka and jauhar when attacked by the Panwar Rajputs. Obliterated was the memory of the Rajput clans offering daughters to Akbar as a show of fealty, of the Mughal Padshah taking part in Hindu rituals involved in the marriages. Now these were recast as brutal acts of coercion, of an emperor ruthlessly carrying out his desires, subjugating the Rajput peoples to his violent will.

Meanwhile, in 1576, as Rana Pratap parsed his lonely but immortal destiny as a Rajput hero, Akbar was seeding the night with light in Fatehpur Sikri and arming his empire with grace.